Visiting Mr. Green

By Jeff Baron

ROSS: **(Pg 9)** Sorry I'm a few minutes late. I never leave work this early, and today, especially, was the wrong day to be doing this, but anyway, here I am.

MR. GREEN: *(totally baffled)* Who are you?

ROSS: *(realizes they've never been introduced)* I'm sorry. *(Offers his hand to shake)* Ross Gardiner. Nice to meet you. You seem to be doing okay. I'm glad . . . **(Pg 10)** Mr. Green . . . I'm going to start coming here every week.

MR. GREEN: For what?

ROSS: **(Pg 11)** I can go shopping for you. It looks like it's not so easy for you to get around. It must be hard for you. Since the accident, I mean.

MR. GREEN: How did you know about that?

ROSS: That's why I'm here. For the next six months, I'm coming here once a week to help you. I don't really have a choice. I have to. I got charged with reckless driving in the accident.

MR. GREEN: You had an accident too?

ROSS: *(loses it)* It was the ***same accident***! I was driving the car you walked in front of. ***That's*** why I'm here. My punishment is community service. You're lucky you weren't killed.

INTRODUCTION

Think about all the divisions in the world. We humans have an inexhaustible capacity to focus on what separates us rather than on what brings us together. Whether it's religion, ethnicity, nationality, race, gender, sexual orientation, or any of the innumerable other ways we classify each other, focusing on the "right and wrong" of differences leads to nothing but fear, separation and conflict. Jeff Baron in his play Visiting Mr. Green addresses many such separations. Ultimately the decisions each person makes are his own. I hope this selection inspires thought, because I have no answers; I won't identify right or wrong. That decision is up to you.

Visiting Mr. Green by Jeff Baron

FOR

ROSS: **(Pg 13)** Hi, Mr. Green. It's Ross Gardiner.

MR. GREEN: **(Pg 14)** What are you doing here?

ROSS: *(sighs wearily)* The social worker sent me back to the Judge. I told him you don't want me to come. He said I have to. *(Holds up the mail)* Here's your mail. It was all over the floor downstairs. Looks like you have some bills and a few letters in there.

MR. GREEN: This is ***your*** mail you're so concerned about?

ROSS: Come on, Mr. Green. For now, we're stuck with each other. *(Holds out a paper bag)* I brought you some food. It's Kosher. **(Pg 15)** *(losing his patience)* Listen, I know you don't want me here, and I don't want to ***be*** here. If you want to eat it, eat it. If you don't want to, don't.

MR. GREEN: *(Mr. Green begins eating hungrily)* It's not like Yetta made.

ROSS: *(after a moment)* That was your wife? How long ago did she pass away? **(Pg 16)** Tell me about Mrs. Green. I know she was a good cook. What else?

MR. GREEN: Nothing else. She's gone. She left me.

ROSS: *(after a moment)* Mrs. Fanelli, the social worker, told me you don't have any children.

MR. GREEN: No. I don't. Gone. Everyone's gone. . . . **(Pg 21)** Are you Jewish?

ROSS: Who told you I wasn't? Well, Mr. Green . . . I don't remember my *bris*, but apparently, I had one. My father's an expensive lawyer . . . what else . . . hey, **(Pg 23-24)** were you born here?

MR. GREEN: In this apartment?

ROSS: No. Here in the United States.

MR. GREEN: Of course. My parents came over right after the trouble in Kishinev.

ROSS: Kishinev?

MR. GREEN: You don't know Kishinev? You're supposed to be Jewish. In Kishinev, which is in Russia in case you don't know, they ran through the street killing Jews. Hundreds of Jews. They threw us in jail for no reason, they took our money for no reason. You want to beat us, you want to rob us, you want to kill us? Go ahead. The police don't mind. The czar doesn't mind. So, when you left, you weren't moving, you were getting the hell

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out of there. You heard about this from your grandparents, right?

ROSS: Actually, I never knew my grandparents. They died before I was born. *(looks around room)* [This] pace really, really needs a cleaning.

MR. GREEN: Yetta always cleaned.

ROSS: **(Pg 25)** How long were you married?

MR. GREEN: Fifty-nine years. She was a wonderful wife. She came and helped me out at the store.

ROSS: What kind of store?

MR. GREEN: A dry cleaner. Downstairs. I had to stop working about ten years ago. I got sick . . . **(Pg 27)** What do you do for a living? It's not important. You make a good living, right? So why aren't you married? *(Silence from Ross)* **(Pg 30)** You know, Ross . . . I think the Good Lord sent you to me. And I hope he sends someone to you. Someone just like Yetta. *(Off Ross's shrug)* Believe me, find yourself the right girl and you'll . . .

ROSS: There ***is*** no right girl. Not for me, Mr. Green.

MR. GREEN: I'm telling you, Ross. For every boy . . . there's a girl.

ROSS: *(after a pause)* Not if you're gay.

MR. GREEN: What?

ROSS: Gay *(off Mr. Green's uncomprehending look)* Homosexual *(Still not registering)* A ***faygele***.

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ROSS: **(Pg 31-40)** So, Mr. Green . . . about last week . . . you know, the thing I told you . . . *(Mr. Green remains silent)* I was just wondering . . . all week, actually . . . if you feel . . . you know . . . okay about it.

MR. GREEN: Okay. Okay. I feel okay *(let's change the subject already tone)* So . . . you brought food? *(Ross puts his briefcase down, puts the deli bag on the table and goes into the kitchen to put the food away)*

ROSS: I found out where my grandparents are from . . . Pinsk.

MR. GREEN: I know Pinsk. *(after a long pause)* It's near Minsk.

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ROSS: *(after a pause)* So . . . I got some good news this week . . . I got promoted.

MR. GREEN: So now you can afford to get married. It would be so terrible?

ROSS: *(frustrated)* It wouldn't be terrible . . . if I were interested in women. But as I already told you . . . quite clearly . . .

MR. GREEN: *(interrupting)* Maybe you didn't know this. Jewish boys are not ***faygeles***.

ROSS: What are you talking about? Some of them are. *(a beat)* Listen, I wasn't planning to tell you I was gay. I just happened. I was almost gonna come here tonight and tell you I met a very nice woman. A very nice ***Jewish*** woman.

MR. GREEN: *(pleased)* You did?

ROSS: No. I was gonna make up that story so we could pretend what I told you last week wasn't true. But we're friends, right. I don't want to lie to you.

MR. GREEN: *(thinks for a moment, then)* You know, Ross . . . I'll tell you the truth. ***I*** was a little bit scared of the girls, too.

ROSS: I am ***not*** scared of women.

MR. GREEN: *(gets up, picks up the deli bag)* Maybe I'll clean up a little.

ROSS: Why can't we talk about this? *(Off Mr. Green's silence)* We're both grownups. Why does this have to be such a big deal? *(Then to himself out loud)* I'm ***sick*** of it being such a big deal *(Starts pacing, then with stored-up frustration)* I don't get it. I really don't get it. One minute I'm the perfect son – they love me, they're crazy about me, they can't stop bragging to their friends about me . . . And the next minute . . . literally the next minute . . . they treat me like I murdered someone. This was years ago, and we still haven't talked about it. It wasn't as if I lied to them my whole life. ***I*** thought I was straight, too. Well, I wondered about it.

MR. GREEN: *(interrupting)* Ross . . . Maybe I don't have to know all this.

ROSS: No, you do . . . So, when you tell me to find a nice girl and get married, you'll know why I can't sit here with my mouth shut. *(a beat)* I mean I ***can***. I have. But really, Mr. Green . . . I'm almost 30 years old. *(Mr. Green motions for Ross to continue)* I go to a party one night, and I meet this guy, Paul. It was like for the first time in my life, I could relax. I

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was just . . . in love. It was great. Until this one Saturday morning. I'm alone in my room, and my mother comes in and sits next to me on my bed and says, "Ross . . . are you and Paul . . . more than friends?"

MR. GREEN: She asked you that?

ROSS: I know I couldn't believe it. I was ***not*** ready to have that conversation, but there she was . . . So I just said yes.

MR. GREEN: What did she say?

ROSS: Nothing. She started crying. I kept saying, "Mom, It's okay. I'm really happy. You've met him. He's a great guy. But she stopped listening. And we never talked about it again. My dad, on the other hand, just stopped talking to me. Completely. He wouldn't even look at me. I didn't know what to do. I became completely self-conscious. Am I acting gay? Do I walk like I'm gay? Is this a gay tie? My mission in life was to never say or do anything that might make someone think I was gay. So I wouldn't go anywhere in public with Paul. I still loved him and he still loved me, and when we were alone, things were great . . . but the rest of the time. *(remembers painfully)* I basically pretended he didn't exist. *(after a moment)* I can't believe I did that to him. So I haven't touched or kissed another person in four years. I sort of got used to it. I thought I did. But I'm ***not*** used to it. I hate it.

MR. GREEN: *(after a moment)* No. You shouldn't be alone. . . . But Ross . . . Not a man.

ROSS: *(Taken aback)* Why not?

MR. GREEN: You know why not . . . It's not what God wanted.

ROSS: How do you know what God wanted?

MR. GREEN: You only get a baby with a man and a woman.

ROSS: Did you and Mrs. Green have a baby every time you made love? Of course not. You were together for almost sixty years without having a baby. How is that different from me being with a man. Do you really think God wants me to be alone?

MR. GREEN: No. He wants you to be with a woman.

ROSS: Then why did he make me attracted to men?

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MR. GREEN: That's your decision, not God's.

ROSS: Oh, I see. One day I just ***decided***. Why not make my life fifty times more difficult? What a good idea. What a smart decision.

MR. GREEN: Listen Ross . . . You're not like them. They act like women . . . they touch each other in the toilet . . . they bother little boys . . .

ROSS: Wait a minute. Do you really believe that? *(Off Mr. Green's silence)* You do. You have no idea what you're talking about. *(Thinks for a minute)* You're doing the same thing you said people did to Jews. "They smell funny, they lie, they heat, they're all pickpockets."

MR. GREEN: It's not the same. We've always been persecuted. How are you persecuted? You have money, you have a good job. . .

ROSS: Yeah. As long as I pretend I'm straight. As long as I keep laughing at stupid gay jokes. . . Every day. You don't know how hard that is.

MR. GREEN: You call that persecution. You're not persecuted. Not like the Jews. What about the Holocaust?

ROSS: What ***about*** the Holocaust? The Nazis were killing Jews ***and*** homosexuals. This isn't a contest. All I'm saying is that being Jewish, you know what it's like to be hated for something you can't change.

MR. GREEN: You can change.

ROSS: No, I can't. I can ***pretend*** I'm not who I really am. I've been doing it most of my life. I'm sick of it. . . . A week ago, you said the Good Lord sent me.

MR. GREEN: A week ago I didn't know you were a ***faygele***.

ROSS: Well now you know. But that's all you know. You don't know a thing about the Good Lord. He's not some narrow-minded bigot like you.

MR. GREEN: Get out of my house! Get the hell out! *(after a moment)* You and my daughter. You think you know everything.

ROSS: *(stops in his tracks)* Your ***daughter***? *(Mr. Green looks away)* You have a daughter? *(Mr. Green doesn't respond)* You told me]you don't have any children. What's her name?

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MR. GREEN: Rachel. Her name was Rachel. *(thinks, then with stored up anger)* You wanna know how you're like Rachel? You think ***you*** wrote the Torah. You think you can change all the rules. You can't do that! If she stayed home where she belonged, she would have met a ***Jewish*** boy and given her mother grandchildren. But she's gotta run off to college with the goyim and break her mother's heart. Thanks to you two, no more Jews will be born. You're finishing the job for Hitler.

ROSS: *(after a moment)* So she married someone who wasn't Jewish. **(Pg 42)** Does Rachel know her mother passed away? *(no response)* She doesn't, does she?

MR. GREEN: Maybe you never learned this. There are rules. There are laws. The law says if you marry a ***goy***, you're dead. Rachel is dead. We sat ***shiva*** already.

ROSS: *(can't believe it)* And that was it? You never talked to her again. . .

MR. GREEN: *(angry)* **(Pg 46)** Rachel, Rachel. You don't know Rachel. Rachel destroyed my family.

ROSS: I don't think so.

MR. GREEN: What are you saying? *(Furious)* ***You're*** telling ***me*** how to be a father? What the hell do ***you*** know?

ROSS: *(frustrated)* Nothing. I don't know anything. *(after a moment)* All I know is you have to tell Rachel her mother is gone.

MR. GREEN: **(Pg 48-49)** But . . .

ROSS: But what?! *(Off Mr. Green's silence)* Mr. Green, I had a terrible day, and I just can't . . .

MR. GREEN: What was terrible?

ROSS: You really wanna know? I went out for lunch today. It was a 60th birthday party for my father. Twelve people at a big table – his friends, his partner, my mother, my cousins and me. The waiter comes in to take our drink orders. He's obviously gay. My father, who is standing sort of behind the waiter, starts making fun of him, imitating his mannerisms. I say to him, quietly, "That's enough, Dad." The waiter leaves and my father gets up and does an impression of the waiter. *(Acts out his father as the effeminate waiter)* "We have some delightful specials for you today." *(as himself)* Then

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he turns to my mother *(As his father being the waiter)* "Those earrings. They're fabulous!" *(as himself)* I can't take it anymore. I say, "Stop it, Dad. He stops. He turns to me and says, "Relax, Ross. We're in New York City. Our waiter's a fag. It's not gonna make the national news." And everyone laughs. I say, "Oh yeah? Well so is your son." Then everyone's quiet. Very quiet. Then my father says, "Well, maybe you can get a job here." Everyone laughs. I leave. That's it.

MR. GREEN: What do you expect?

ROSS: I expect to be able to go out with my father and not be humiliated.

MR. GREEN: Think how he must feel. With his friends. With his family.

ROSS: ***I'm*** his family. *(a beat)* Why am I even talking about this with you? . . . . Tell me, Mr. Green. Because I really want to understand this. You found out Rachel wasn't gonna be what you wanted her to be, so you sat shiva and you never saw her again. Were you really able to go on with your work and your marriage and never even think about your only daughter? *(a pause)* How could you to do that? Did your religion help you do that? . . . *(silence)* She isn't dead. *(a beat)* I gotta get out of here *(Ross heads for the door)*

MR. GREEN: Ross . . . *(long pause)* I never did. *(this is hard to say)* I never stopped thinking about her. About Rachel. *(Ross doesn't know what to say. He just stands there. After a moment, Mr. Green motions for Ross to come over. He opens his arms. Ross walks over and Mr. Green takes him in his arms. They comfort each other)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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